

Sensations of Loneliness for American Adults on Online Dating Platforms

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Introduction:

Dating apps have skyrocketed in use over the past decade, with the United States user base reaching 60.5 million in 2024 and projected to grow to 67 million by 2029 (Statista, 2025). In addition, 30% of all adults in the United States report having used dating apps in the past (Vogels & McClain, 2023). Some herald dating apps as a net benefit, citing the assistance they provide in meeting others with common interests (Anderson et al., 2020). However, dating apps remain riddled with numerous negative effects, the most prominent of which is the loneliness arising from an overuse of these applications (Penny & George, 2025). Online connections lack authenticity at their foundational basis, hindering “real” connections from occurring between individuals (Otte, 2019). This can cause feelings of disconnection from each other, which makes a particular relationship less likely to succeed (Wotipka & High, 2016). When one party wants a relationship to end, they could engage in ghosting, defined as the act of suddenly cutting off communications with another, commonly without any explanation or prior notice (Carter, 2025). Ghosting may initiate a prevalent feeling of loneliness and isolation within both parties (Carter, 2025). These feelings can result in long-term mental and physical damage to those afflicted by it, with reports by the US Surgeon General (2023) stating that the mortality comparison odds of lacking social connection are greater than smoking 15 cigarettes a day. These issues with dating apps generate the following question: “How should the isolating effects caused by dating apps for its American audience be best reduced?” To address this question, we will first examine the perceived positive effects of dating apps that have produced their large user base and expand on the feelings of loneliness that are caused by the use of dating apps. Then, we will discuss the modern policies that worsen these isolating sensations before finally considering the solution of

introducing elements of offline relationships into online dating platforms to raise the authenticity of relationships and lower feelings of loneliness.

The Appeal of Dating Apps

Many individuals continue to use dating apps as a result of perceived positive effects that they feel dating apps provide. Some claim dating apps elevate the self-esteem of those who use them. In 2024, more than 50% of online dating service users in the United States reported that dating apps had a net positive effect on their self-esteem (Statista, 2025). Cherry Liu (2024), an economist from the London School of Economics and Political Science, provides a possible explanation through the algorithmic processes and brain chemistry. Liu states that when we “swipe” through profiles on dating apps and find a “match,” our brains perceive this as a reward, triggering dopamine bursts and elevating feelings of enjoyment and satisfaction in users. Dating apps also provide multiple sources of external validation, which could enhance feelings of self-fulfillment for the users (Khamassi et al., 2025). Many authors challenge this perspective on dating apps, however, arguing that dating apps have the potential to damage self-esteem through their constant expectation of comparisons, pressure for perfection, and internalized rejection, all of which could incur a net negative effect on the confidence of their users (Kushnir, 2025; Burdin, 2024). While this idea of dating apps as self-esteem boosters may be debatable, the idea that dating is a useful place to find significant others is less so, with several individuals stating that it was easy to find other individuals whom they found attractive and shared common interests. As a result, most individuals described their experience with dating apps positively (Anderson et al., 2020). This likely accounts for the high rates of dating app use among contemporary adults, with 30% of all adults in the United States stating that they have used

dating apps in the past (Vogels & McClain, 2023). Overall, dating apps have significantly risen in popularity in the United States, but the specific appeal of the dating apps for their users remains debated, with various scholars claiming self-esteem, validation, and usefulness as their main selling points.

Causes and Effects of the Loneliness Caused by Confusion on the Authenticity of Users

Many people who use dating apps can become disillusioned with the legitimacy of relationships found through these methods, which can cause users to feel lonely. Dating app users, in an attempt to receive validation from others, present an altered version of themselves, posting photos that highlight positive traits that they might not necessarily possess. This behavior has been recorded to come at the cost of authenticity (Degen & Kleeberg-Niepage, 2021; Zhang et al., 2025). Clinical psychologist Lara Otte extends this problem into social media as a whole. When addressing the apparent contradiction of greater feelings of loneliness in the interconnected contemporary age, Otte claims that the majority of online communications serve as “performative relationships” rather than “meaningful, human connections,” and that our fears of being criticized create a sense of disconnection from others, constantly fueling the pressure to solely post positive attributes of our lives (Otte, 2019). This decrease in authenticity can cause a lack of trust and vulnerability, preventing the occurrence of real relationships and fueling feelings of isolation (Otte, 2019; Miah, 2024).

While authenticity by itself is a big factor in causing feelings of loneliness, the lack of authenticity can drive other correlating causes that amplify these isolating effects, such as ghosting. When individuals feel that a particular dating profile isn’t authentic, they lose trust in the other individual, making a relationship less likely to succeed (Wotipka & High, 2016). If this

eventually leads to an individual wanting out of a relationship, they might engage in ghosting to avoid a confrontation, particularly if the individual is emotionally immature (Carter, 2025). Some people who ghost others lack a negative intent, perceiving it as being less painful than a direct explanation for the cause of rejection (Timmermans et al., 2020). However, ghosting often has an adverse effect, elevating anxiety and decreasing self-esteem in the individual ghosted (Langlais et al., 2024). Critically, ghosting can cause increased feelings of loneliness to those on the receiving end (Navarro et al., 2020; Timmermans et al., 2020). This is a wide problem in online dating, with 60% of all adults in the United States reporting having been ghosted in the past (Statista, 2023).

Increased feelings of loneliness can cause severe damage to the individual at hand, both emotionally and physiologically. According to a report by the US Surgeon General Vivek Murthy on the loneliness epidemic within the United States (2023), social connectivity can influence our biology, psychology, and behavior. The mere sensations of isolation can cause inflammation, stress, and promote unhealthy coping methods. These factors can contribute to negative health outcomes, such as heart diseases and strokes, and may increase the chances of morbidity and mortality (Murthy, 2023).

Overall, dating apps can engender feelings of loneliness in their users, primarily because of the inability to discern the authenticity of relationships made on these platforms, preventing the creation of genuine connections. While this factor by itself can cause sensations of loneliness, this is supplemented by the rise in ghosting behavior that the lack of genuine connections promotes, which further damages the self-esteem and increases feelings of loneliness of the afflicted individual.

Dating App Corporation Strategies

The current system of dating apps only exacerbates this issue. In an article by Sian Boyle (2024), a journalist associated with the City University of London, he states that most dating platforms are designed to maximize revenue by increasing user retention. Many dating apps attempt to achieve this by likening themselves to gambling products, constantly exposing users to paid features that they claim would boost their chances of a match. These features lock the user into using these apps, lengthening the usage time (Boyle, 2024). Many sources state, however, that longer usage of dating apps is directly correlated with higher levels of depression and anxiety, eventually resulting in higher feelings of isolation. In addition, this can instill gambling behaviors in its users, leading to addictive and compulsive behaviors that continue this cycle of loneliness (Balki, 2025).

Centrally, this means that dating companies do not want users to enter committed relationships, as this causes adults to stop using these apps (Balki, 2025). As a result, companies have no incentives to increase authenticity in the connections between users, as this would increase the chances of producing a successful relationship. As authenticity is a primary issue that causes loneliness, corporations must be forced into potential solutions that raise authenticity through government policies (DiVito et al., 2026). Current policies, such as the Romance Scam Prevention Act and the Online Dating Safety and Transparency Act, mainly focus on preventing online fraud and promoting online safety (Lalota, 2025; Perez, 2026). These laws fail to address the issue of the loneliness induced by dating apps, nor the lack of authenticity within the presentation of individuals online. Overall, there is a lack of current policies that force dating apps to adopt initiatives to raise authenticity among their users.

Adding Elements of Offline Relationships Into Dating Apps

Many sources report that in-person interactions can help alleviate feelings of loneliness for those involved (Miah, 2024). Therefore, by incorporating elements of offline relationships and connections into online platforms, we can potentially prevent the rise in feelings of loneliness for online users as well.

There are several elements of offline relationships that we can incorporate into the dating surface. One method is to set daily limits on the number of profiles an individual can view. In offline relationships, there is often a logistical limit to the number of people that one can meet in a single day, and daily limits would replicate this into the online sphere. First, this modification would limit the choice overload on the individuals involved, allowing greater certainty in each decision made (McStay, 2023). Many individuals have reported that choice overload is a principal reason why people choose to ghost others (Timmermans et al., 2020). If we reduced this burden on individuals, we would be able to reduce the number of people getting ghosted, thereby reducing overall loneliness. In addition, this would veer away from the infinite profile scroll that the current system has. Infinite swipe loops are a feature that promotes compulsive dating use, rather than making meaningful connections (Wilen et al., 2025). By removing the infinite swipe loop in favor of a system that emphasizes each encountered profile, meaningful connections become stressed, and loneliness can be alleviated. The incorporation of this solution is plausible. The idea of including daily limits for matches is the central operating principle of the platform “CoffeeMeetsBagel,” which has been celebrated for its effectiveness (Bram, 2016).

Another possible method to incorporate real-world frictions into the online dating sphere is to prevent users from seeing the profile pictures of their partners immediately after a match. Only after engaging in text conversations with the partner are you able to see the other user’s

profile. Like how offline relationships are built through communication rather than superficial characteristics, this method would increase the significance of personality and fit, developed through meaningful conversations. By limiting the ability to view profile pictures, the pressure to demonstrate an overidealized version of oneself is lessened, allowing for greater authenticity in behaviors and greater trust between users. Through fostering genuine relationships, we can minimize the feelings of loneliness for both users involved. This solution is confirmed to be plausible, as this idea is the core philosophy of the dating app “S’more” (Carson, 2020).

Both these ideas have limitations, centrally arising from the lack of incentives for corporations to engage in these solutions. As stated above, the central goal of dating platforms is to maximize the user’s usage time. The first of these solutions is completely antithetical to this goal. Adding dating limits and veering away from the compulsory infinite scroll would decrease the time spent on the apps, and therefore would be less than ideal for corporations. Therefore, if daily limits are to be incorporated en masse into dating apps, it would likely have to be mandated through a government law or policy.

Overall, the idea of adding realistic frictions to the dating world remains a potentially lucrative solution. Its effects can increase authenticity, boost chances of a successful relationship, and alleviate feelings of loneliness for its users. Due to the lack of incentives for dating companies to adapt these changes into their platforms, we must proceed by legally mandating the incorporation of daily limits and limited visibility of profile pictures on these dating apps.

Conclusion

In contemporary society, dating apps have increasingly grown into one of the principal methods to meet new people and enter relationships. However, this has created increased feelings of loneliness for its users, primarily due to the lack of authenticity in the relationships generated by dating apps. While this factor by itself can create feelings of loneliness, it can cause the supplementary effect of ghosting, which worsens these feelings in those afflicted by it. To avoid these feelings of loneliness, we must add components of offline dating into the online sphere by way of legal mandates to pressure corporations into adopting these ideas. By adopting these principles, we can best begin to move on from the heavy feelings of loneliness that dating apps afflict onto its users.

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